REFLECTION

وَتُدْلُوا بِهَا إِلَى الْحُكَّامِ

Bribery: The Sin We Stopped Noticing

Al-Baqarah 2:188

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REFLECTION

Bribery: The Sin We Stopped Noticing

2:188, 5:42 and two hadiths

Bribery is a major sin in Islam. In Surah Al-Baqarah (2:188):

وَلَا تَأْكُلُوا أَمْوَالَكُم بَيْنَكُم بِالْبَاطِلِ وَتُدْلُوا بِهَا إِلَى الْحُكَّامِ لِتَأْكُلُوا فَرِيقًا مِّنْ أَمْوَالِ النَّاسِ بِالْإِثْمِ وَأَنتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ ﴿١٨٨﴾

"Do not consume one another's wealth unjustly, and do not offer it to the authorities so that you may knowingly and sinfully take a part of other people's wealth."

Allah also describes people who are سَمَّاعُونَ لِلْكَذِبِ أَكَّالُونَ لِلسُّحْتِ *"eager listeners to lies, greedy eaters of what is forbidden"* (5:42). The word سُحْت (*suht*) covers unlawful earnings, and the early scholars named bribery as one of its clearest examples.

It has become normal

Whenever I visit the subcontinent and other developing countries, I see how deep this goes. Many of us who grew up there do not think twice when we go back. A small payment to skip a

queue, to get a job, a loan, a plot of land, a contract, a vote. It has even reached the arrangements for Hajj.

I once watched a man who had just finished Umrah and i'tikaf pay a porter to jump the long check-in line for the flight home. I am sure he did not think much of it. I could not believe my eyes.

Who is the bigger sinner?

Many people think only the one who takes the bribe is guilty. The Prophet ﷺ made no such difference:

- **Both are cursed:** 'Abdullah ibn 'Amr reported that the Messenger of Allah ﷺ cursed the one who gives a bribe and the one who takes it (Tirmidhi 1337).
- **Especially in judgment:** Abu Hurayrah reported that he cursed the one who gives and the one who takes a bribe to sway a judgment (Tirmidhi 1336).

And Allah knows best.

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